Zohran Mamdani’s Political Rise: What the Evidence Shows

Research report drafted from the v2 analytics dataset (election, polling, finance and campaign-mechanism files). Source IDs such as S01 refer to `sources.csv`*. Figures are as recorded in the dataset and should be re-checked against official records before publication.*

1. Summary

This report asks one question: **how did Mamdani build an electoral coalition, and what evidence supports the roles of affordability messaging, grassroots organizing, social media, campaign finance and ranked-choice voting?**

The dataset supports a clear account of *what happened* in the 2025 Democratic primary and a partial account of *why*. It does not support strong causal claims, and it does not yet contain the geographic or message-level data needed to describe the coalition itself. The main findings are:

- **Polling support rose sharply.** Emerson polls recorded Mamdani at 10% in March, 23% in late May and 32% in June, while Andrew Cuomo’s share fell from 38% to 35% (S06, S07, S08). These are distinct polls with different populations, not a panel.
- **He won the first-choice count, not only the final round.** Mamdani took 469,642 first-choice votes (43.8%) to Cuomo’s 387,137 (36.1%) (S01). Ranked-choice tabulation widened his margin rather than reversing the result: the final round was 573,169 (56.4%) to 443,229 (43.6%).
- **Final-round transfers favored him roughly 65/35.** Of the first-choice votes that went to other candidates, about 159,600 ended up with one of the two finalists; about 64.9% of those went to Mamdani.
- **Affordability was the dominant message in the one content analysis we have.** An outside analysis found price or affordability terms in 78% of Mamdani’s coded ads and videos versus 32% of Cuomo’s (S12). That is a content measure, not evidence of persuasion.
- **Organizing figures are large but self-reported.** The campaign reported about 50,000 volunteers, 1.5 million doors and 2.1 million calls (S10). None of this is independently audited.
- **Finance shows a heavy public-funds and small-donor profile, alongside heavy independent spending against him.** Independent expenditures supporting Cuomo ($31.0m) and opposing Mamdani ($21.9m) exceeded the $16.5m his own committee disbursed (S04, S05).

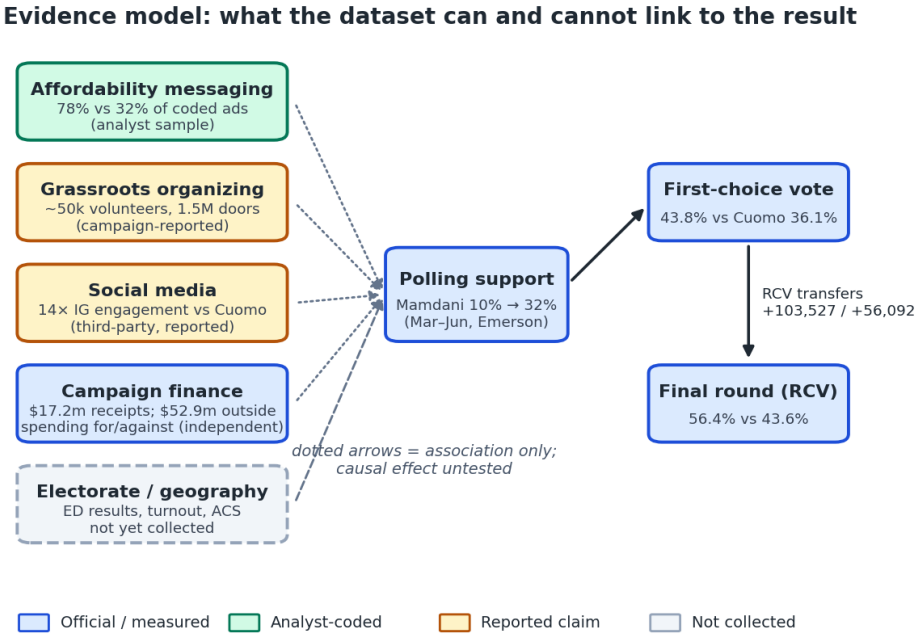


Figure 1. Evidence model. Each factor is colored by the quality of the evidence in the dataset; arrows show hypothesized associations, not established causal effects.

The rest of this report sets out the evidence for each claim, its limits, and what would be needed to go further.

2. Research design and data

2.1 What the dataset contains

Evidence area	File	Status
Election results (2020, 2024, 2025 primary)	`timeline.csv`, `primary_results.csv`	Populated
Ranked-choice rounds	`rcv_rounds.csv`	Populated
Polling	`polling_observations.csv`	Starter series (5 rows)
Campaign finance	`campaign_finance.csv`	Populated, mixed scopes
Field, digital and message indicators	`campaign_mechanism_indicators.csv`	Populated, reported claims
Election-district results and demographics	`geographic_election_template.csv`	Blank
Coded posts, ads and speeches	`message_coding_template.csv`	Blank
Full poll records	`polling_template_full.csv`	Blank

Blank templates are intentional. Anything in this report about geography or message-level patterns is a research plan, not a finding.

2.2 Evidence standards used here

The README's integrity rules are applied throughout. Actual results are kept separate from polls and simulations. Candidate-controlled finance is kept separate from independent spending and public funds. Reported claims are labeled as such. Correlation and timelines are not treated as causal evidence, and neighborhood-level patterns are never used to infer individual voters.

3. Timeline of a political career

Date	Milestone	Evidence
2020-06-23	Won the Democratic primary for State Assembly District 36 with 8,410 votes	NYS BOE (S03)
2020-11-03	General election: 38,221 votes, listed as unopposed	NYS BOE (S03)
2021-01	Began serving as Assembly member	Official record still to be added
2024-11-05	Re-elected: 37,911 votes, listed as unopposed	NYS BOE (S03)
2024-10 (approx.)	Announced mayoral campaign	Exact date to be confirmed
2025-02	Emerson polling reported him at about 1%	Secondary report (S09)
2025-03-26	Emerson: Mamdani 10%, Cuomo 38%	Poll release (S08)
2025-05-23/26	Emerson: Mamdani 23%, Cuomo 35%	Poll release (S06)
2025-06-23	Emerson: Mamdani 32%, Cuomo 35%; simulated RCV 52–48 for Mamdani	Poll release (S07)
2025-06-24	Primary: 469,642 first-choice votes (43.8%)	NYC BOE (S01)
2025-07-22	RCV result certified: 56.4% to 43.6%	NYC BOE (S01)
2025-11-04	General election won, per election reporting	Official totals not yet in dataset (S02)

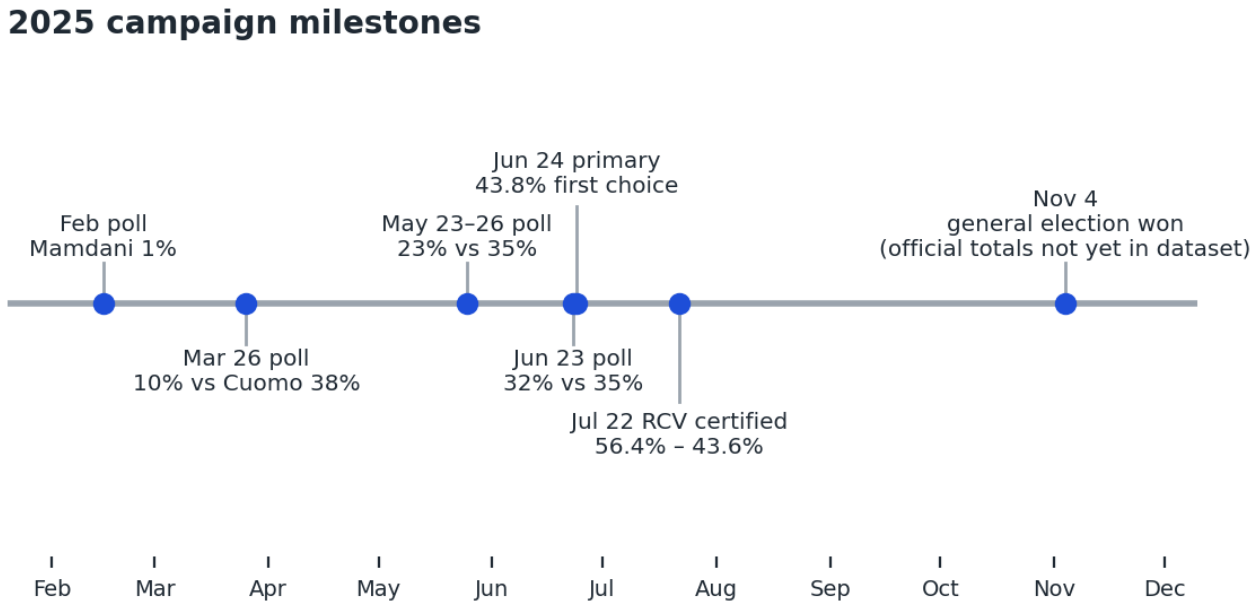


Figure 2. Milestones of the 2025 campaign recorded in the dataset.

Two cautions apply. First, the 2020 and 2024 Assembly generals were unopposed, so the 38,221 and 37,911 totals are turnout-driven and say little about contested-race strength. Second, the

2020 primary (8,410 votes) is a district-level result and is not comparable in scale to a citywide primary of more than one million ballots. The Assembly record shows a base of local electoral success; it does not by itself explain citywide support.

4. Polling before the primary

4.1 What the polls recorded

Poll	Mamdani	Cuomo	Gap	Notes
Feb 2025	1%	n/a	n/a	Secondary report; original release to be linked
Mar 2025	10%	38%	−28 pp	Sample detail not recorded
May 23–26	23%	35%	−12 pp	Primary-voter subsample, n=606, ±3.9 pp
Jun 2025	32%	35%	−3 pp	Sample detail not recorded
Jun 2025 (RCV simulation)	52%	48%	+4 pp	Simulated final round
Actual first choice (Jun 24)	43.8%	36.1%	+7.7 pp	Official result
Actual final round	56.4%	43.6%	+12.8 pp	Official result

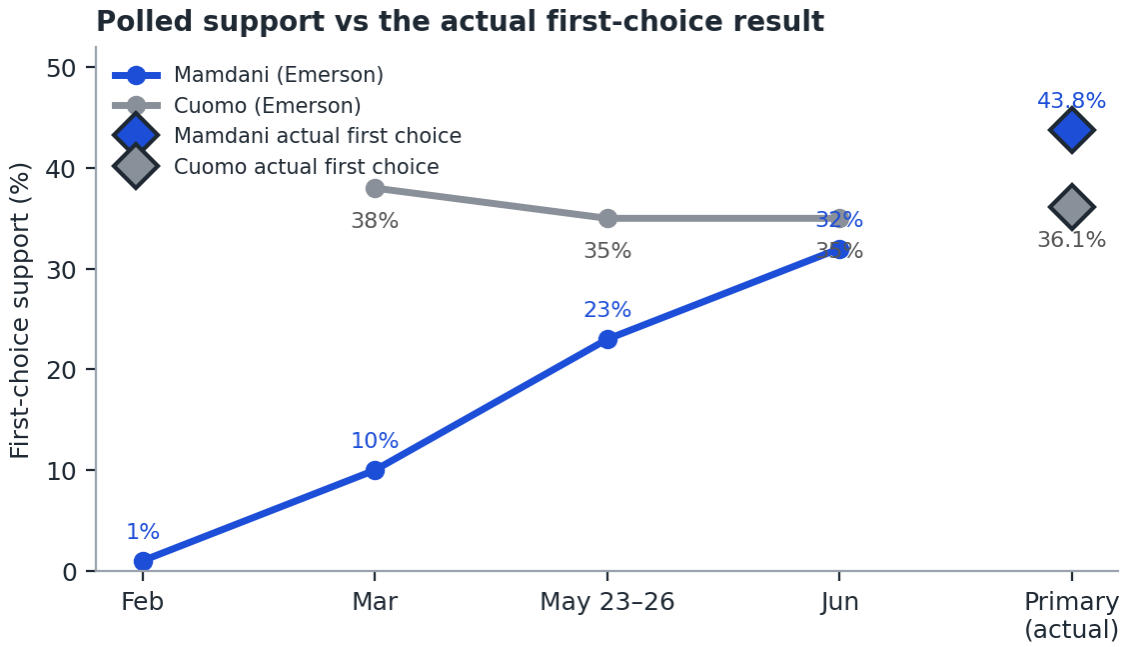


Figure 3. Emerson first-choice polling compared with the actual first-choice result (diamonds). Polls are different samples and are not a panel.

4.2 Interpretation

The direction is unambiguous: Mamdani's measured support grew at each observation, and Cuomo's lead shrank from 28 points to 3. Cuomo's polled share was relatively stable (38% → 35% → 35%) and landed close to his actual first-choice share (36.1%). Nearly all of the movement in this series is on Mamdani's side.

The comparison with the actual result is where care is needed. The last poll's 32% understated Mamdani's actual first-choice share by about 12 points, and the simulated final round (52%) understated his actual final share (56.4%) by about 4 points. But the polls and the election

measure different things. Polls include undecided respondents and are fielded among a sampled population, whereas the result counts ballots from actual voters. The dataset also does not record the undecided share, field dates or sample sizes for several polls. It would be a mistake to call this a “polling miss” on this evidence alone.

4.3 Limits on the polling evidence

- Five rows from one pollster are a starter series, not a trend model. There is no basis for fitting a growth curve or testing for the timing of a change.
- The May poll used a primary-voter subsample (n=606); other releases may use different populations. The README warns against comparing these directly to all-registered-voter results.
- The February figure comes from a secondary report, and the dataset itself flags that the original release should be linked.
- Having no other pollsters means pollster-specific effects cannot be separated from real change.

5. Primary results and ranked-choice voting

5.1 First-choice results

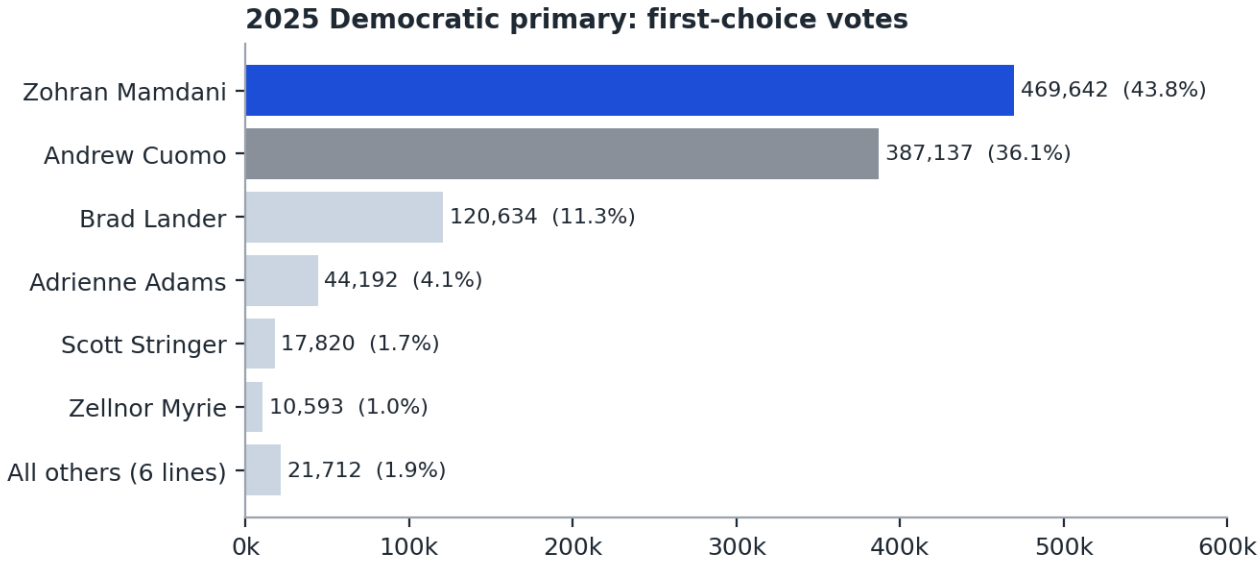


Figure 4. First-choice votes in the 2025 Democratic mayoral primary (NYC BOE, S01).

First-choice ballots totaled 1,071,730. The two finalists together held 856,779 (79.9%); the other 214,951 ballots (20.1%) were distributed among the remaining candidates, led by Brad Lander (120,634; 11.3%) and Adrienne Adams (44,192; 4.1%).

5.2 What the rounds show

Stage	Mamdani	Cuomo	Inactive ballots
Round 1 (first choice)	469,642 (43.82%)	387,137 (36.10%)	0
Round 2 (write-in transfers)	469,755 (+113)	387,377 (+240)	n/a
Final round	573,169 (56.39%)	443,229 (43.61%)	55,332

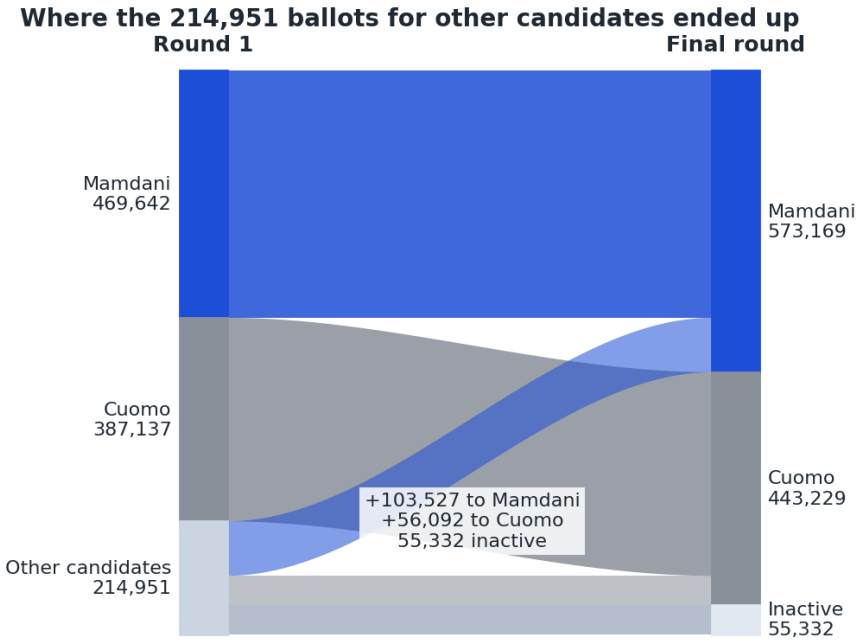


Figure 5. Flow of ballots from round 1 to the final round. Band widths are proportional to vote counts; bands for retained votes are shown in full color and transfers in lighter shades.

From round 1 to the final round, Mamdani gained 103,527 votes and Cuomo gained 56,092. Summing those gains gives 159,619 ballots that moved to a finalist. Together with 55,332 inactive ballots, that reconciles exactly to the 214,951 first-choice ballots cast for other candidates. Mamdani received 64.9% of the transfers that reached a finalist.

5.3 What ranked-choice voting did and did not do

The second research question asks how much ranked-choice tabulation changed the outcome. On these data, the answer is that **it changed the margin, not the winner.** Mamdani led after first choices by 82,505 votes (7.7 points). After transfers he led by 129,940 votes (12.8 points). The result would have been the same winner under a plurality count.

Two points follow. First, the lopsided transfer pattern indicates that voters whose first choice was a third candidate ranked Mamdani above Cuomo about two to one when they ranked either. Second, transfers describe voter *rankings*; they do not tell us why those voters ranked as they did, nor whether an endorsement, a campaign appeal or something else drove them (hypothesis H4). The dataset also does not allow us to say how many Mamdani voters ranked other candidates, because that requires the cast vote record.

The 55,332 inactive ballots (5.2% of first-choice ballots) are ballots with no remaining ranked finalist. They are not votes for either candidate and should never be added to a candidate’s total.

6. Affordability messaging

6.1 What the evidence says

The only content-level evidence in the dataset is a Searchlight Institute analysis of ads and YouTube and TikTok videos (S12). It found price or affordability terms in 78% of Mamdani's coded ads and videos versus 32% of Cuomo's. The same source reports a post-election exit poll in which 51% of NYC voters named affordable prices among Mamdani's top three issues, versus 24% who named it among the national Democratic Party's top three issues.

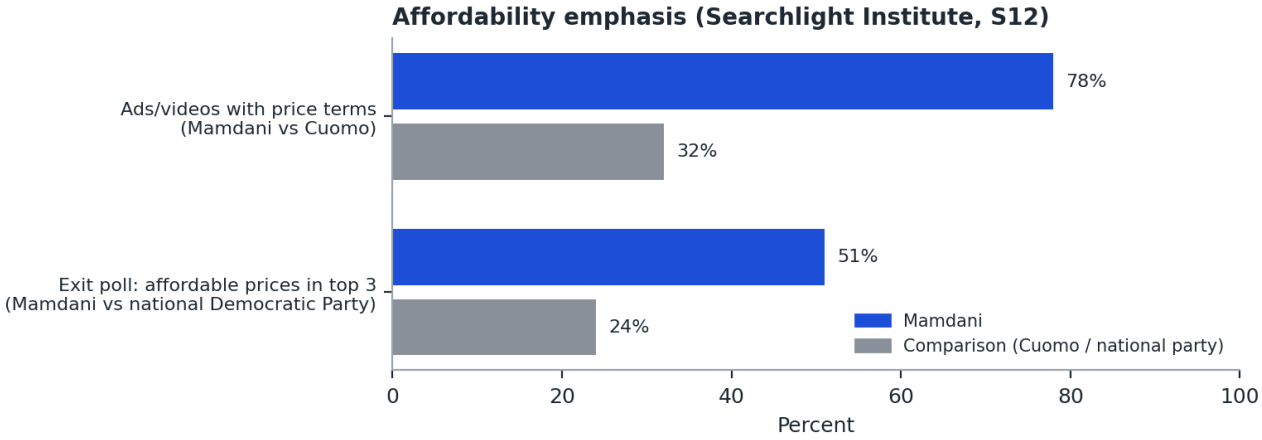


Figure 6. Affordability measures from the Searchlight Institute analysis. The two comparisons answer different questions and use different samples.

6.2 How far this goes

These figures support a descriptive claim: *affordability terms appeared far more often in Mamdani's coded content than in Cuomo's, and voters surveyed afterward associated him with affordability more than they associated the national party with it.* That is consistent with hypothesis H1.

They do not establish that affordability messaging persuaded voters, and several limits matter:

- The content corpus is analyst-selected; scope, coding rules and "affordability term" definitions determine the percentage. The 78% and 32% should not be read as shares of all campaign communication.
- The 51% and 24% figures answer different questions (Mamdani's top three issues vs. the party's top three issues), so the gap between them is not a like-for-like comparison.
- The source is a post-election analysis. Without time-stamped content, there is no way to say whether messaging changed before the polling changes, or after.
- Message-coded data of our own is absent: `message_coding_template.csv` is blank. The planned coding of topics such as housing, transit, childcare and public safety has not been done.

The messaging claim is therefore "well-supported as a description of emphasis, untested as an explanation of support."

7. Grassroots organizing and digital reach

7.1 Reported figures

Indicator	Reported value	Basis
Volunteers	50,145	Campaign-reported (S10)
Field leads	499	Campaign-reported (S10)
Doors knocked	1.5 million+	Campaign-reported (S10)
Phone calls	2.1 million	Campaign-reported (S10)
Neighborhoods covered	65+	Campaign-reported (S10)
Instagram automated DMs	144,000	Secondary account (S10)
Clicks from those DMs	45,000	Secondary account (S10)
Instagram engagement vs. Cuomo, June	14×	Washington Post citing Sprout Social (S13)
Social conversation vs. Cuomo, June	30× or more	Washington Post (S13)

Qualitative reporting describes volunteer organizing and distributed leadership (S11), and Brookings' analysis emphasizes registration activity, younger-voter participation, organizing and social video (S09).

7.2 Reading these numbers

The scale of reported activity is consistent with a well-resourced field program. But each number has a specific weakness:

- **Doors and calls are attempts, not contacts.** 2.1 million calls is not 2.1 million voters reached.
- **Volunteers are a count of sign-ups under the campaign's own definition.** No audit exists in the dataset.
- **Clicks are not turnout.** The 45,000 DM clicks measure interest in a link, not voter conversion.
- **Engagement and mention multiples are relative measures** whose platform, time window and definitions matter. Mentions include negative and neutral attention and are not unique users.
- **Field effort is not randomly assigned.** A campaign sends volunteers where it expects to find supporters, so areas with more contact may show higher support for reasons unrelated to contact (H2). Testing this requires contact records and election-district results, neither of which is yet in the dataset.

What can be said is that field and digital activity were large and visible, that they coincided with rising poll support, and that analysts have credited them. What cannot be said is how much they added to the vote.

8. Campaign finance

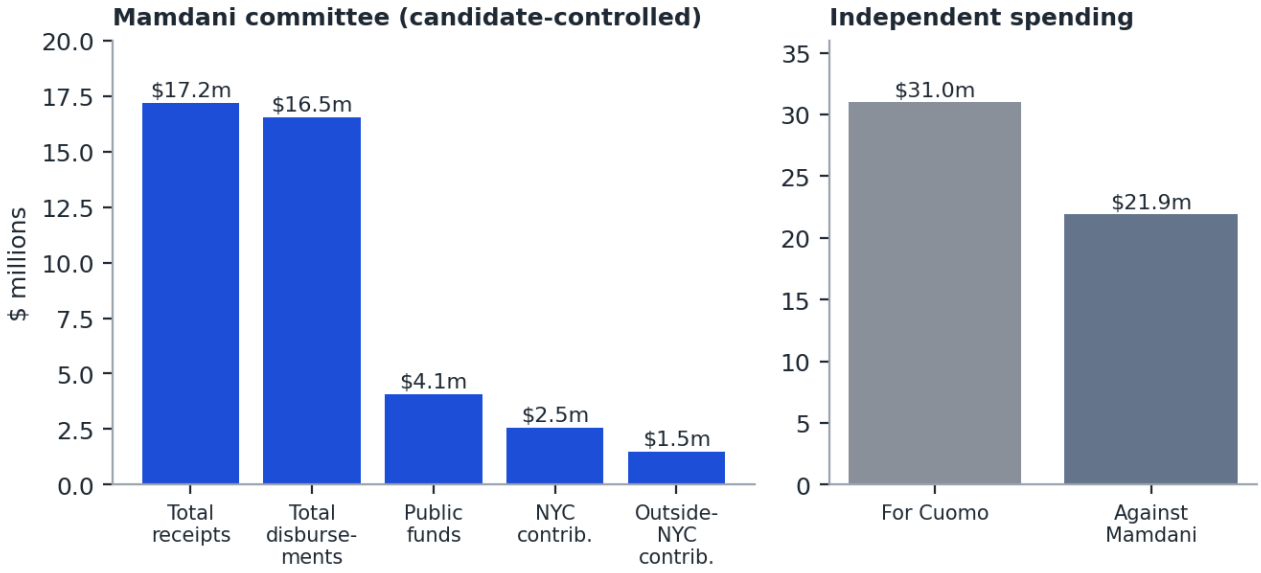
8.1 Three kinds of money, kept separate

Candidate-controlled finance (Mamdani 2025 mayoral committee, S05):

Metric	Value
Total receipts	$17,196,623
Total disbursements	$16,538,094
Public funds received	$4,051,115
Number of contributors	40,824
Average contribution	$99
Contributions from NYC	$2,542,426
Contributions from outside NYC	$1,479,776

Independent expenditures (not controlled by any campaign, S04): $31.0 million in support of Cuomo and $21.9 million in opposition to Mamdani.

Citywide aggregates (all candidates, S04): $123.5m total campaign spending across races; $72.2m in mayoral campaigns; $86.8m in public funds distributed to 131 candidates; $83.2m in independent spending; $41.1m in individual contributions (244,401 contributions, 88.2% under $250, median $50).



Separate categories: not additive. Note the contribution lines and public funds explain only part of total receipts (Section 8.3).

Figure 7. Candidate-controlled figures for Mamdani's committee (left) and independent spending reported by the CFB (right). These categories are not additive.

8.2 What the data show

Three observations are supported:

1. **Public funds were a substantial but not dominant share of his receipts.** $4.05m is about 23.6% of $17.2m in total receipts. The $86.8m distributed across 131 candidates shows the program was cycle-wide, not unique to him.

2. **Outside money was larger than his own spending.** Combined independent spending for Cuomo and against Mamdani ($52.9m) exceeds Mamdani's own disbursements by a factor of more than three. These categories are reported separately by the CFB and are not added here to total "money spent on the race"; the point is a relative one about scale.
3. **A meaningful share of identified contributions came from outside NYC.** Of the $4.02m in the two geographic categories listed, 36.8% was from outside NYC. This is a share of those two lines only, not of total receipts.

8.3 Data-quality flag

The $2.54m (NYC) and $1.48m (non-NYC) contribution lines sum to $4.02m, and 40,824 contributors at a $99 average is about $4.04m. Both are close to each other but only about a quarter of $17.2m in total receipts. The dataset does not explain what the remaining roughly $9m consists of once public funds are accounted for. Possible explanations include timing of the summary snapshot, categories not shown, or matching-fund payments shown differently. This should be resolved with the CFB Data Library (S17) before any statement about the share of funding from small donors. The 40,824 contributors (people) also cannot be compared with the 244,401 contributions (transactions) citywide.

8.4 Missing comparison

The dataset has no candidate-level finance for Cuomo, Lander or the other candidates, so the report cannot say how Mamdani's receipts, contributor counts or spending mix compared with theirs. This is the largest gap on the finance question (H5).

9. Geography, turnout and the coalition itself

The central question refers to a "coalition," but the current dataset describes the *size* of his support and not its *composition*. There is no election-district-level result, no turnout comparison with prior cycles, and no demographic context. Hypotheses H6 (turnout and electorate composition) and H7 (coalition expansion) therefore remain untested.

Brookings and others point to younger-voter participation and new registrations (S09). Those are attributed claims in a secondary source. Verifying them requires:

1. NYC BOE election-district CSVs for the 2025 primary and general (S02);
2. prior comparable primary turnout for the same districts;
3. ACS variables (income, rent burden, age, education) on a documented vintage and geography crosswalk (S18).

When that is done, any analysis stays at the district level. Patterns such as "districts with more renters gave him higher shares" describe places, not individual voters, and must not be rewritten as claims about how renters voted.

10. Limitations and alternative explanations

10.1 Structural limitations

Limitation	Effect on conclusions
Five-row polling series from one pollster	Cannot model trend or timing
Reported (not audited) organizing metrics	Scale is plausible; effect is unmeasured
One content analysis, no raw corpus	Cannot test messaging over time
No ED-level data	Cannot describe the coalition or test field-effect claims
No finance data for other candidates	Cannot benchmark his fundraising
General-election results not in dataset	Findings apply to the primary only
Timeline is event-based	Coincidence is not causation

10.2 Alternative explanations the evidence does not rule out

- **Opponent-side factors.** Cuomo's polled support stayed near 35–38%. Some of the shift could reflect events or attention specific to the opponents (H8) rather than anything the Mamdani campaign did.
- **Consolidation among voters unhappy with the frontrunner.** The 2-to-1 transfer pattern is compatible with ranking decisions driven by dislike of Cuomo, not by affirmative support for Mamdani. The data cannot separate the two.
- **Selection effects in the sources.** Post-election analyses, campaign retrospectives and news features are written about a winner, and they tend to emphasize what worked.
- **Reverse causation.** Rising poll numbers can attract volunteers, donors, attention and engagement, so organizing, money and social reach can be consequences of momentum as well as causes.
- **Compositional change.** If new or returning voters made up more of the electorate, shifts in the polls might reflect who was sampled rather than who changed their mind. Resolving this needs turnout and registration data.
- **Candidate biography and representation (H9).** Coverage of identity and biography may have affected visibility, but individual vote choice cannot be inferred from identity.

11. Conclusions and next steps

11.1 What the evidence supports

- Mamdani's measured support rose substantially between March and June 2025, and he won the first-choice count outright.
- Ranked-choice transfers favored him and enlarged his margin, but did not change the winner.
- Affordability was the most prominent theme in the coded content that exists, and voters associated him with it.
- Reported organizing, digital and finance figures describe a large and unusually visible campaign operation, with substantial independent spending on the other side.

11.2 What it does not yet support

- Any claim about *how much* messaging, organizing, social media or fundraising contributed to the result.
- Any claim about *who* the coalition consisted of, in geographic or demographic terms.
- Any claim about the general election beyond the fact of the win.

11.3 Recommended data collection, in priority order

1. **Election-district results and ACS context** to populate the geographic template and test H6 and H7.
2. **CFB Data Library** files for all mayoral candidates to resolve the receipts reconciliation and benchmark the finance profile.
3. **Full Emerson release details** and other pollsters to turn the starter series into a documented poll table.
4. **A coded message sample** (100–200 items) with a written codebook, double-coding on a subset and agreement statistics, to support H1 and H3.
5. **Official general-election totals**, if the project is meant to cover the full electoral coalition.

Appendix: data notes

- **Poll row P01** in `polling_observations.csv` has a column misalignment (the note text sits in the sample-size column). Values were read as Mamdani 1% for February; verify against the original release.
- **Finance reconciliation:** see Section 8.3.
- **Final-round sum check:** 573,169 + 443,229 + 55,332 inactive = 1,071,730, matching the first-choice total.
- All time-sensitive figures, especially the dynamic CFB candidate summary, should be re-pulled and dated before final publication.